South Africa's ANC Has Its Worst Election Result Ever

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South Africa's governing party, the ANC, has just had its worst election result ever. Voters spoke in local elections, and even the party called it '**catastrophic**.' The ANC led South Africa out of **apartheid** into **democracy** more than 30 years ago under Nelson Mandela. Since then it has won almost every election. Not this time. The party won a **majority** in just one province, Limpopo. In 2021 it won six. It won the most votes in only two of the eight big cities. The Democratic Alliance came second with 25% of the vote and kept control of Cape Town. Former president Jacob Zuma's MK party came third with 10% and took Durban. 'This has been a very **catastrophic** outcome,' said the party's secretary-general, Fikile Mbalula. He blamed the high cost of living. President Cyril Ramaphosa said the party accepts the result. 'We accept the will of the people,' he said, 'with humility.' The slide began in 2024, when the ANC lost its national **majority** for the first time since 1994. Now the parties have 14 days to agree on **coalitions**.

Word Treasure

catastrophic -- Terrible, or a complete disaster.
apartheid -- The old unfair system in South Africa that separated people by race.
democracy -- A system where people vote to choose their leaders.
majority -- More than half of the votes, or the biggest share.
coalitions -- When parties share power and govern together.

Background you need

The ANC is the party that has governed South Africa for more than 30 years, since the end of apartheid.

Apartheid was an unfair system that separated people by race.

In a democracy, voters choose their leaders, and when no party wins on its own, parties can share power in a coalition.

Break it down

WHO: South Africa's governing party, the ANC, and voters across the country.
WHAT: The ANC had its worst election result ever in local elections.
WHERE: In South Africa, in provinces like Limpopo and big cities like Cape Town and Durban.
WHY: Voters were unhappy, and the party blames the high cost of living.

Why it matters

If you have ever voted for a class leader, this story shows how grown-ups use elections to tell leaders when they are unhappy.

Test what you remember

1. How did the ANC itself describe the result?

- (A) 'Wonderful'
- (B) 'A fair result'
- (C) 'A small setback'
- (D) 'Catastrophic'

2. In how many provinces did the ANC win a majority?

- (A) One
- (B) Two
- (C) Nine
- (D) Six

3. Which party came second?

- (A) The MK party
- (B) The Economic Freedom Fighters
- (C) The Democratic Alliance
- (D) The ANC

4. What did Mr Mbalula blame for the result?

- (A) The high cost of living
- (B) Low voter turnout
- (C) A shortage of candidates
- (D) Bad weather

5. What did President Ramaphosa say?

- (A) The party will ignore the result
- (B) The party will hold a new election
- (C) The party will change its name
- (D) The party accepts the result

6. How long do parties have to agree on coalitions?

- (A) 90 days
- (B) 14 days
- (C) 7 days
- (D) 30 days

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. The ANC's secretary-general, Fikile Mbalula: He called the result 'catastrophic' and blamed the high cost of living.

2. President Cyril Ramaphosa: He said the party accepts the result 'with humility'.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):